

Pawn movement is irreversible

Foundations

THE IDEA

Pawns move forward but capture diagonally. They cannot retreat. A pawn move therefore changes both the squares it controls and the squares it can no longer defend. Even a harmless-looking advance creates permanent consequences.

WORKED EXAMPLE

White's pawn on g2 controls f3 and h3. After g2-g4 it controls f5 and h5 instead. The gain of space comes with a change to the king's shelter, especially if the king is on g1.

TRY IT BEFORE READING ON

What two questions belong before a pawn push near your king?

ANSWER AND REASONING

Which useful squares will the pawn control, and which squares or lines will it leave weak? Then check immediate tactics. The balance depends on the whole position, not on a ban against pawn moves.

TAKE THIS INTO YOUR NEXT GAME

Every pawn push buys something and gives something away.